Shinobi: Art of Vengeance

When a combat system outgrows its enemies

Developer: Megalis Studio
Genre / Platform: Action Beat-Em-Up / Light Metroidvania — PC, Console
Verdict: Recommended with reservations | Played to full completion

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CORE DESIGN PILLAR

What Is This Game Fundamentally About?

The primary player verb is expression through combat. Shinobi hands you a deep toolkit — combos, cancels, chains, customizable magic abilities, a talisman system with active and passive effects — and invites you to find your own style. The emotional goal is ninja power fantasy: fast, fluid, in control. The central tension is supposed to be how do you use everything at your disposal to handle what the game throws at you. In practice, that tension is underdeveloped — which is the design question worth examining.

CORE GAMEPLAY LOOP

Engage → Decide → Act → Feedback → Progress

You enter a semi-open level, engage enemies, explore, and reach a boss. Clearing enemies generates progression currency and unlocks new abilities, feeding back into the next encounter with more tools. Feedback is immediate and tactile — fluid animations, satisfying hit reactions, a live combo counter. What motivates repetition is the pleasure of the system itself and the promise of new moves to experiment with. What escalates is enemy density and boss complexity, though not quite enemy variety in the way the system warrants. The main friction points are in the back half, where levels lean into switch-and-backtrack puzzles that stall momentum — the one resource an action game can't afford to waste.

ONBOARDING & MENTAL MODEL FORMATION

Teaching a Deep System Without Demanding It

The game introduces its combat system gradually and scaffolds complexity reasonably well — but there's a structural gap. Because enemy design never forces variety, players who don't naturally experiment will never surface most of what the system offers. The game teaches you the tools exist; it never creates situations that make you use them. Intrinsically motivated players find the depth. Everyone else finds the path of least resistance and stays on it.

WHAT WORKS & WHAT DOESN'T

Strengths and Trade-offs

- The combo system works because it's expressive without being opaque — cancels and chains are discoverable through play, and the talisman system adds build variety without demanding a deep dive to engage with.
- Boss fights work because they're where encounter design finally catches up with the combat system — they demand variety, create pressure, and give you satisfying use cases for moves you've been sitting on.
- The art direction does real design work, not just cosmetic work — fluid animations and expressive character designs create player investment that makes every other system matter more.

- The trade-off: expressive freedom vs. meaningful challenge. The game didn't want to lock players into hard counters — a legitimate choice — but the cost is that most of the combat system's depth becomes optional in a way that tips from freedom into under-utilization. Streets of Rage 4 had a simpler move set but more precisely tuned enemies. Shinobi has the deeper system and the less demanding roster, and that gap is the central missed opportunity.

> The game hands you a full toolkit and then never quite builds the job that needs it.

REDESIGN PROPOSAL

Expanding Enemy Variety to Surface Combat Depth

Problem	Enemy design doesn't demand enough variety. Most encounters clear with the same core moves available at the start, leaving the combat system's depth largely untouched.
Proposed Adjustment	Introduce enemy types with damage-category weaknesses — fire, lightning, swift strikes — without hard-locking solutions. Players who exploit weaknesses clear faster; those who don't still get through. Expressive freedom is preserved; pressure to explore is added.
Expected Impact	Wider move usage, more varied and replayable encounters, and a tighter alignment between what the combat system offers and what the game actually asks of you.
Risks	Elemental matchups can feel out of place in a pure action game. Mitigation: keep weaknesses as efficiency bonuses, not hard gates, and signal them through enemy visual design rather than UI overlays.
What I'd Measure	Skill usage variance — the spread of moves used per session, before and after the change. A wider distribution in the updated version indicates players are genuinely exploring the system. Secondary metric: time-to-clear on new enemy encounters, to confirm the efficiency incentive lands without creating frustrating difficulty spikes.

DESIGN TAKEAWAYS

What I'm Taking From This

- Combat systems and encounter design need to be developed in conversation with each other from the start — not sequentially. The sandbox came first here, and it shows.
- Onboarding a deep system requires more than introducing it. If the game never creates situations that push players to use what it's teaching, most of that teaching is invisible.
- Momentum is a design resource. The late-game backtracking spends it carelessly in a game that runs on it.
- Aesthetics aren't separate from the design conversation — great art direction creates investment that makes every other system matter more.